

The Overthinker's Journal



The Overthinker's Journal

A Teen Guide to Quieting a Racing Mind

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

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This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

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For anyone whose brain refuses to close its tabs.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Nothing in it is a test, and there is no wrong way to use it. Some pages will hit exactly right on a hard day. Others will feel like nothing. That is normal. Move on.

There are five sections inside. Grounding tools you can use in the moment, when your body is in the middle of it. Prompts to help you get the loud thoughts out of your head and onto paper, where they get a little smaller. Trackers to help you notice patterns — what triggers your anxiety, what actually helps, how sleep and mood connect. A toolkit of small practices for the hard days. And eight weeks of short reflections at the end.

You do not have to go in order. If a prompt feels wrong today, turn to another one. If a tracker doesn't fit your week, skip it. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

A few small suggestions:

- If your mind is loud, start with a grounding tool from Section One. Sometimes your body has to steady before your thoughts will.

- Try one prompt a day for a week, then look back. You'll see patterns you couldn't see in the moment.
- Try one tracker for a full week before deciding whether it helps. Patterns take time to show up on the page.
- Write in pencil, pen, marker, whatever. Scribble. Doodle in the margins. Leave a page half-empty. This journal will not grade you.
- If you fill a page and want more room, use one of the notes pages at the back. They're there on purpose.

One important thing: this journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe — please also talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a mental-health professional. There are resources at the back of the book. You do not have to do this alone.

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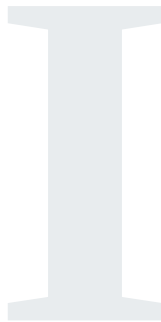
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SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.



PRACTICE

5-4-3-2-1

A classic sensory grounding exercise. When your thoughts are racing faster than you can catch them, your senses can pull you back into your body. Take your time with each step. There is no rush.

1. Name five things you can SEE. Say them out loud or in your head.
2. Name four things you can TOUCH. Actually touch them if you can.
3. Name three things you can HEAR. Distant sounds count too.
4. Name two things you can SMELL. Or two smells you like.
5. Name one thing you can TASTE. Or one taste you'd like right now.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Box breathing

A simple breath pattern used by athletes, first responders, and anyone who needs to steady a racing nervous system. Four counts in, four hold, four out, four hold. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you go — one side per count.

1. Breathe in slowly through your nose for four counts.
2. Hold your breath gently for four counts.
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for four counts.
4. Hold empty for four counts. That's one full cycle.
5. Repeat four times. Notice how your body feels different at the end.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Body scan

Anxiety lives in the body — tight jaw, clenched shoulders, shallow breath. A slow scan helps you locate where you're holding it, so you can start to let it go. There is no wrong way to do this.

1. Start at the top of your head. Notice how it feels.
2. Move down slowly: forehead, jaw, neck, shoulders.
3. Continue down: chest, belly, arms, hands, hips.
4. Keep going: legs, knees, ankles, feet.
5. Where do you feel tight? Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's okay too.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Cold water reset

A temperature shift is one of the fastest ways to interrupt an anxiety spiral. Cold on the face triggers the mammalian dive reflex, which slows your heart rate on purpose. Sounds strange. Works fast.

1. Go to a sink, or grab an ice cube or a cold drink.
2. Splash cold water on your face for 30 seconds — especially your forehead and cheeks.
3. Or: hold an ice cube in your palm until it starts to melt.
4. Or: run cold water over your wrists for 30 seconds.
5. Breathe slowly while you do it. Notice the shift.

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

PRACTICE

Name it to tame it

Vague, big feelings feel unmanageable. Specific, named feelings feel smaller. Being precise about your emotion shrinks it a little and gives you something to actually work with.

1. Pause. Ask: what am I actually feeling right now?
2. Skip 'bad.' Try more specific words: anxious, angry, disappointed, embarrassed, lonely.
3. Say it out loud or write it down: 'I feel _____ because _____.'
4. See if you can name a second feeling underneath the first one.
5. Notice — did naming it change the size of it at all?

WHAT DID YOU NOTICE?

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

Get the loop out of your head and onto the page.



NO. 01

What thought have you been on a loop with today? Write it out until it runs out.

NO. 02

If your mind is a browser, how many tabs are open right now?

Name them.

NO. 03

Which of your worries have you already thought about more than once this week?

NO. 04

What is a decision you've been re-deciding? What would 'good enough' look like?

NO. 05

Write down the worst-case scenario in full. Now write how you'd actually handle it.

NO. 06

What are you overthinking because you care? What are you overthinking out of fear?

NO. 07

Finish this: 'I keep thinking about it because...'

NO. 08

Which of your worries are you actually solving, and which are you just circling?

NO. 09

Write down every 'what if.' Then, next to each, write 'and then what?'

NO. 10

What conversation are you rehearsing in your head? Write the version you'd actually say.

NO. 11

What is one thing you cannot know right now, no matter how long you think about it?

NO. 12

What would it feel like to be done thinking about this for tonight?

NO. 13

Whose voice is loudest in your head when you spiral? Is it yours?

NO. 14

What's the story your brain keeps telling? What's a truer, kinder version?

NO. 15

What is a small action that would move this forward more than more thinking?

NO. 16

Write the message you want to send, but don't send it. What did you learn?

NO. 17

Where do you feel the overthinking in your body? What do you notice?

NO. 18

What is the thing you're afraid to decide? Set a deadline for the decision.

NO. 19

What would you tell a friend who was thinking about this as hard as you are?

NO. 20

What has your overthinking never once solved for you? What has it cost?

NO. 21

What is one worry you can hand off — to tomorrow, to a friend, to no one at all?

NO. 22

Write down three worries. Rate each 1-10 for 'how likely is this, really?'

NO. 23

What would you do next if you trusted yourself to figure it out along the way?

NO. 24

What is a decision past-you made that turned out fine? How did that feel then?

NO. 25

What if the thing you're worried about isn't actually the point?

NO. 26

What is the smallest thing you could do right now to interrupt the loop?

NO. 27

What thought are you ready to be done with, at least for tonight?

NO. 28

Write about a time your overthinking was wrong. What actually happened?

NO. 29

Finish this: 'The version of me that isn't overthinking would...'

NO. 30

What does 'done thinking about it' look like tonight? Write yourself permission.

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your racing-thought episodes.



TRACKER

Anxiety level this week

Rate your baseline anxiety each day. Note what set it off and what helped.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Sleep tracker

How many hours, how well, and how you felt the next day. Patterns show up fast.

DAY	HOURS SLEPT	QUALITY 1-10	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Mood check-in

Three quick check-ins each day. One word each is enough.

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Racing-Thought Episodes log

Notice when it shows up. What was happening? What did you do next?

DAY	WHEN AND WHERE	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Energy this week

What drained you. What refilled you. Both matter.

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

One small win

Every day, name one small thing. Toast that wasn't burnt counts.

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO NOTICED	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TRACKER

Kindness to self

One kind thing you did for yourself each day. Rest counts. Naps count.

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

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Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.



PRACTICE

Close the tabs

List every open worry in your head like browser tabs. Star the ones worth keeping open. Close the rest by writing 'not today' next to them.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The 10-10-10

Ask: Will this matter in 10 minutes? In 10 months? In 10 years? Write your honest answer to each. Notice how the size of the worry shifts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Worry window

Give yourself a 15-minute worry window. Set a timer. Write down everything your brain wants to worry about. When the timer ends, close the book.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Name the loop

Write the exact sentence your brain is stuck on. Read it out loud three times. Ask: is this a fact, a fear, or a story?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The next tiny step

You do not need the whole plan. Write the single smallest next action. Do that. Come back to this page after.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Reframe it

Write the anxious thought at the top. Underneath, write what you would tell a friend who said this to you. Notice the tone difference.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Park it for tonight

Write your worry on a page. Close the book. Tell yourself: 'It will still be here in the morning if I need it.' Try to leave it here.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

What I can control

Draw a small circle inside a bigger one. Small circle: what you can actually do. Big circle: what's outside your reach. Keep your attention in the small circle.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

The 5-minute rule

Pick the thing you've been avoiding by overthinking it. Set a timer for 5 minutes and start. Then stop. Write about what came up.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Body first

Overthinking is often a signal that your body needs something. Drink water, eat, move for five minutes, or step outside. Then check in.

TRY IT NOW.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- I do not have to solve every thought.
- Not deciding is also a decision I can rest in.
- One clear next step is enough.
- My worry is not my future.
- I can put this down for tonight.
- I trust myself to figure it out as it comes.
- Overthinking is not the same as caring.
- I am allowed to close the tabs.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.



PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 1 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 2 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 3 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 4 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 5 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 6 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 7 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking back

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

TRY IT NOW.

PRACTICE

Week 8 · Looking forward

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

TRY IT NOW.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

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